approximately USD 6.00. End note) Francois concluded the study by stating that a minimum daily wage of HTG 200 would result in the loss of 10,000 workers in the sector.

7. (SBU) ADIH Executive Director Gregor Avril and HOPE II factory owner Clifford Apaid admitted that the prospect of the law, coupled with the weak global economy, has caused approximately 1,000 job losses during the last month. One factory (a HOPE II legislation beneficiary) closed and other factories have closed down lines and dismissed newly employed workers. According to Avril and Apaid, the garment industry, represented by ADIH, has met with Preval on three occasions and has presented the impact of the HTG 200 minimum wage to over 40 members of Parliament and political parties, who they believed afterward to be sympathetic to the sector's findings.

Comment

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8. (SBU) Controversy over the minimum wage issue continues to ramp up. Some members of Parliament, notably Benoit, demand that the President sign the law as currently written while they entertain private sector pleas for a reconsidered or phased-in minimum wage even if only to show that they did confer.

9. (C) Despite Preval's meetings with Parliament and the private sector on how to manage the minimum wage legislation without killing investment and job creation, he has said little in the face of continuing student demonstrations. Haitian National Police (HNP) and Ministry of Justice officials are convinced these "students'' are being funded and mobilized by interests that go far beyond the university; it remains unclear who is fomenting the disturbances.

10. (SBU) Although the numbers of protestors remain relatively small, numbering 500 to 1,500, the HNP has had to use tear gas frequently to control the crowds and the police appears stretched then. While the demonstrations could peter out as the academic year ends and students leave campus, there are worrying signs that the demonstrations may be picking up steam.